Shared Rumour, Divergent Meanings: Political Interpretation and Public-Search Findability in the Hong–Kangxi Discourse on Xiaohongshu

Abstract

In November 2025, a historical rumour that the Kangxi Emperor was a secret son of a Ming defector spread across Chinese social media. Amid funny meme-making, three kinds of serious interpretations emerged: the first recast Qing rule as foreign conquest (Anti-Manchu/Qing), the second combined it with a pre-existing grassroots theory that Western history is fabricated (Anti-West), and the third used uncertain paternity to question why national continuity is imagined through fathers at all (feminist-lineage). This article examines how these interpretations were distributed within a single online event, and whether a post could still be found six months later varied with its interpretation kinds, cultural materials, or the main location of its searchable texts. I collected 1,594 event posts in November 2025 and then attempted to find these posts again in April 2026. I then analyze how survival varied with post content. The outcomes show that most posts don't propose any of the three interpretations, and that feminist-lineage posts and posts that referenced a famous traditional novel, *Dream of the Red Chamber*, were less findable six months after they were originally scraped. Anti-Qing posts, which opposed official historical narratives most directly, were no more likely to be difficult to find after six months. Posts whose main message was carried by image and which could only be read by OCR were harder to find. In all, post findability after six months did not follow a simple distinction between politically oppositional and nonpolitical content.

1 Introduction

In early November 2025, a historical rumour circulated widely on Chinese social media: the Kangxi Emperor (1654–1722), one of the best-known Qing rulers in imperial Chinese history, was not the biological son of the Shunzhi Emperor but the secret son of Empress Dowager Xiaozhuang and Hong Chengchou (洪承畴), a Ming official who surrendered to the Qing. In the following, I call this rumor and its circulation the "Hong–Kangxi event."

Ming was the last Han-dominated dynasty, while the Qing that replaced it was an ethnic minority regime. Ethnic tension and ethno-nationalism made "Oppose the Qing and restore the Ming" (反清复明) a powerful rallying cry among traditional Chinese secret societies through hundreds of years, and was even utilized in modern republican revolutions. It acted as a catalyst for mass mobilization but was soon transformed into a driving force for modern nation-building by elites. Its influence, however, can still be observed, which is the background of the rumor's popularity.

Shortly after it was proposed, the rumour became entangled with a broader and rapidly changing

cluster of discussions often described as a "Mourning Ming" (悼明, literally mourning for the fall of Ming) wave. On Xiaohongshu (小红书), a lifestyle platform known internationally as RedNote and dominated by female users, the rumour became a hot topic.

The posts about the Hong–Kangxi event shared a stock of names, dates, and cultural materials, such as Hong Chengchou, the Kangxi Emperor, the year 1644 when Ming fell, and *Dream of the Red Chamber*, one of the most important Chinese traditional novels, but they have diverse positions. Many of them treated the rumour as gossip, playful spectatorship, or a historical puzzle. I focus on others that interpreted the event in a politically meaningful way: anti-Manchu/Qing posts treated Qing rule as foreign conquest or as a rupture in Han-centred historical continuity; anti-West posts linked the event to pre-existing online discourse Western Pseudohistory / *Xishi Bianwei* (西史辨伪, literally "discerning forgeries in Western history"), claiming that Western history, science, or civilization had been fabricated from or stolen from ancient China; feminist-lineage posts used the uncertainty about imperial paternity to question why dynastic legitimacy, blood continuity, and political belonging should be imagined through paternal descent.

These interpretations relate differently to dominant official narratives of Chinese history. Anti-Manchu/Qing interpretations directly challenged the inclusion of the Qing dynasty within a continuous, multi-ethnic nation (Mullaney, 2011; Leibold, 2016). Anti-Western pseudohistory partly overlapped with the national humiliation framework that attributes China's misery and trauma to nineteenth-century foreign aggression, though its claims depart from official historiography (Wang, 2012). Feminist-lineage interpretations shifted the discussion to question the patrilineal lineage through which family and dynastic continuity are conventionally constructed (Shiga, 1967; Hong Fincher, 2018), so seemingly was not related to modern politics, but feminism itself has been oppressed on Chinese internet.

The anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation also received an explicit official response. In December 2025, Zhejiang Publicity (浙江宣传), a provincial Party media account, published a commentary criticizing this interpretation and called it the "1644 view of history" (locating the starting point of China's misery in 1644). The commentary described this view as treating the Ming–Qing transition as a break in Chinese civilization and warned that it could divide China's officially recognized ethnic groups (Zhejiang Publicity, 2025).

This event raises a broader question about online censorship. When an online event raises an official warning, outright deletion is one possible outcome, but online content can also become harder to find without being removed. A post may remain online while getting harder to reach through search filtering, keyword blocking, and altered rankings (Roberts, 2018; Gillespie, 2022). Research on China also shows that censorship is selective and often implemented through platforms rather than directly by the state (King et al., 2013; Sun and Zhao, 2022).

However, while existing research has documented what gets censored (collective action potential, sensitive intellectual topics), less is known about whether censorship operates differentially

within a single event, whether censorship treats structurally similar content differently based on its narrative. Here's where the Hong–Kangxi event can contribute. What's unique for this event is that most of its posts are simply funny meme-making, and three serious interpretations related to official narratives in subtly different ways, which makes it meaningful to explore the fate of its posts. However, I did not obtain stable author IDs when the posts were collected, so I cannot verify deletion for every post. But I can test whether each post remained findable through Xiaohongshu's public search box.

It's also worth noting that Xiaohongshu posts often embed text within images and stickers rather than in the caption or body text. Do posts that carry their core message in images/stickers (rather than in searchable caption text) show different survival rates than text-primary posts? This distinction matters because platforms may care about content's political meaning but must infer it from observable features such as words, images, repeated references, user reports, and indexed text.

This study therefore asks two questions. First, how were the three political interpretations distributed across the Hong–Kangxi event's larger gossip and playful spectatorship corpus? Second, did later public-search findability differ with a post's political interpretation, the cultural material it used, or the location of its message? If posts become less findable when they challenge official history more directly, anti-Manchu/Qing posts should be the least findable, when holding cultural material, message location, and posts' other traits constant.

I collected 1,594 Hong–Kangxi event posts during the November 2025 wave and re-searched each post through Xiaohongshu's public search in April 2026. A post is counted as findable when searching its opening words or body text can return it. After re-searching all the posts, I randomly sampled 100 posts and checked, finding that posts that aren't returned may be no longer visible on an identifiable author profile, or may remain on a profile but do not appear in public search. Then these posts were coded for interpretation, type of participation, cultural material, and message location with the help of LLMs.

The findings were unexpected. In adjusted logistic models, the anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation showed no stable association with later findability, while feminist-lineage posts are less likely to be found. Posts using *Red Chamber* decoding material, and posts whose message is carried mainly by image text were also less findable, even though some of them made no explicit political claim. That suggests that, in an event receiving official warning, the content's findability may not follow a simple distinction between politically oppositional and nonpolitical content. But this outcome cannot be treated as equal to intentional censorship, since platform rules and technical settings such as recommendation algorithms can also shape the outcome.

The findings also matter for research on digital nationalism. The Hong–Kangxi event shows that even a single topic may have diverse forms of grassroots nationalism. Some posts narrowed Chinese historical membership around the Han, while others redirected foreign injury narra-

tives toward Western pseudo-history, which is easy to slide to conspiracy and needs further exploration.

The case also documents a form of feminist speech directed at historical genealogy, surname inheritance, and dynastic succession rather than at a current policy issue, therefore extending existing online feminism studies' scope.

2 Divergent Political Uses of a Shared Rumour

This section explains the official historical account and cultural materials involved here, and the forms of participation in this study.

2.1 The Official Historical Narrative

Previous studies pointed out that the People's Republic narrates Chinese history through a set of connected premises. The most salient one is that China is a unified multi-ethnic nation. The membership categories of China were shaped by a state-led ethnic classification project launched in 1954, whose taxonomy was consolidated over subsequent decades into today's official framework of fifty-six ethnic groups (Mullaney, 2011). Within this framework, the Qing dynasty (1644–1912) that was founded by Manchus belongs inside Chinese history, and its border governance supports China's modern territory claims.

In addition, the starting of Chinese modern history is mainly described and learned as a story of national suffering and rising again. The "century of humiliation" was opened by the Opium War of 1839–1842. Since then till the building of the People's Republic, the trauma and catastrophe were caused by foreign imperialism (Wang, 2012: 39–70). Since the 1990s, these premises have been institutionalized through the patriotic education campaign, which made humiliation and redemption the backbone of history teaching (Wang, 2012: 95–118).

These claims were historically contested. Different Chinese governments defined the nation so differently that Fitzgerald describes modern China as a "nationless state," a state that summons into being the nation it claims to represent (Fitzgerald, 1995: 77). Popular understandings of history also do not always reproduce these state-sponsored accounts (Sinkkonen, 2025). Partly because of that, the Ming–Qing transition, Manchu rule, and how trauma is narrated are still subjects that can be interpreted differently. The Hong–Kangxi rumour brought these contests into online discussion, to some degree re-opening the definition of "Chinese" in forms of historical discussion and citing traditional political orthodoxy concepts. Previous literature has noted the practice of bringing back the traditional Han-centric / Sino-barbarian ethnic imagination rejected by the state narrative, especially among right-wing populism, but has not studied well how the platforms and state respond to it (Zhang, 2019).

2.2 Anti-Manchu/Qing Interpretation

Instead of blaming the West as the main sinner and seeing 1840 as the starting point of national trauma, the anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation in the Hong–Kangxi event treats the Qing conquest or Qing rule as the source of national trauma. Qing replacing Ming is seen as a foreign conquest and Han subordination, which leads to cultural destruction and the beginning of China's decline, finally the surrender to the West. Most of the posts cite historical records about massacres exerted on Han by Manchu, and forced changes in dress and hairstyle and literary inquisitions that destroyed the culture, as evidence.

A strand of these posts introduces bloodline lineage, which actually implies patriarchy thoughts. For example, some posts treated the supposed replacement of the Manchu paternal line by Han descent as an ironic reversal of the Qing conquest: the dynasty that had conquered the Han was "replaced" by Han again from within. Others attributed Kangxi's governance ability and cultural sophistication to his alleged Han birth father. These readings equate paternal bloodline with the essence of a child, or even a whole dynasty. Still others take it as evidence that imperial genealogy and official history themselves could have been falsified. In this version, the rumour joins a broader suspicion of Qing historiography or even official historiography, proposing the possibility of concealed "true" history.

Another strand moves to a class view of history. Some posts argue that the decisive problem was the ruling order created after the Ming collapse: Han collaborators and Manchu elites formed a political class that continued to dominate the population regardless of the emperor's biological ancestry. Here ethnic conflict and class conflict are combined or treated as alternatives, and netizens argued about how we should learn the history.

The disagreement concerns whether the Qing was a foreign dynasty or a Chinese dynasty, therefore whether Qing rule should be included within the history from which modern China derives political and territorial continuity. As an alternative definition of "Chinese," this interpretation regards the Han as core of the Chinese nation and places the Manchus and the Qing outside it or at least lower than Han. Previous scholars have cautioned against treating ethnic groups as fixed entities, since political actors struggle over where category lines are drawn and who falls inside (Brubaker, 2004: 7–27; Wimmer, 2013: 1–15, 44–78). Anti-Manchu/Qing can almost be seen as a boundary-making practice described by scholars.

But such practices are not something new on the Chinese internet. As early as 2010, James Leibold traces an online Han-centrist current that mobilizes the Han against the official multi-ethnic framework and casts Qing rule as alien domination (Leibold, 2010). Kevin Carrico's ethnography of the Han Clothing Movement shows a similar current offline, complete with conspiracy theories of continuing Manchu control and a narrative in which the Manchu conquest "contaminated" Chinese culture (Carrico, 2017: 1–15, 35–39, 131–158). Han-nationalism of this kind has been contained by the state's own territorial nationalism so far (Leibold, 2016),

and popular nostalgia for imperial glory circulates through commercial history media that the government only weakly controls (Yu, 2014). It's likely that the Hong–Kangxi event gave this pre-existing current a new and highly engaging carrier.

2.3 Anti-Western Pseudo-History Interpretation

The second interpretation builds on a pre-existing online discourse often called *xishi bianwei*, literally "discerning forgeries in Western history." Its claims vary in scope. Some argue that particular Western scientific, technological, or cultural achievements were taken from China and later presented as Western inventions. More expansive versions question the authenticity of Western archaeological sites and civilization recorded in history books. The Hong–Kangxi posts entered this discourse as another example of a supposedly falsified historical record.

This interpretation sometimes overlapped with anti-Qing arguments. Some posts portrayed Qing rulers, Han collaborators, and Western missionaries as cooperating to suppress Chinese knowledge and transfer or "steal" Chinese achievements to the West. In this account, the Qing conquest, literary inquisitions, restrictions on knowledge, and later Western domination are threaded into a causal and time line. The result partly resembles the official national-humiliation narrative in assigning injury to foreign powers, but moves the beginning of that injury back toward the Ming–Qing transition and blames Qing rule as the main cause.

This interpretation also relies on a particular way of judging evidence. Debunking rumors by scholars and mainstream media can itself become evidence of concealment, aligning with conspiracy theory's "stigmatized knowledge" (Barkun, 2013: 12, 26–27). Textbooks, historians, archives, and scientific institutions all can be described as suppressing the truth. Some extreme versions extend this logic into the present, alleging that descendants of Qing elites continue to influence current politics, and lacking evidence from authoritative sources becomes evidence. One post, for example, derived the Italian word *machina* from Mozi and "China" as evidence that European machinery originated in ancient China. When another user asked for scholarly support, the response was that genuine documents would never be made available to "yellow people."

In my corpus, only 14 posts are coded as Anti-West, so the regression cannot estimate it precisely. But this cannot indicate the size of the broader pseudo-history discourse, or the scale of using Pseudo-History materials in this wave. The crawl separately captured 593 posts related to pseudo-history, which are kicked out because they are not related to the Hong–Kangxi event; and as I observed, many pseudo-history posts in the Hong–Kangxi event circulate without using common Hong–Kangxi keywords or pseudo-history keywords. Since I cannot obtain all posts through keyword crawling, I cannot estimate the broader prevalence of this interpretation.

2.4 Feminist-Lineage Interpretation

The feminist-lineage interpretation shifts the dispute away from whether the Qing was a legitimate Chinese dynasty toward the patrilineal thoughts. If Kangxi's paternity can be doubted three centuries later, these posts argue, that is because paternity is always unreliable and can be forged, while maternity is knowable in birth. Yet dynastic legitimacy, surname continuity, ancestral ritual, and by extension the nation's imagined continuity are all constructed through the paternal line, which is absurd.

The most widely circulated post in this interpretation later became a slogan, recasting ancestral halls and genealogy books as imagined substitutes for the bloodline certainty that belongs to women, and re-attaching "dragon vein," the metaphor of sovereign continuity conventionally carried by male succession, to the maternal line. It also inverted a familiar saying about history's malleability, "history is a little girl whom anyone can dress up," into "history is a little boy whom anyone can pass around for adoption", so the malleability of history is no longer seen as a passive girl but the male heir, whose origins are arranged by others.

The critique targets historically institutionalized patrilineal succession. Classical Chinese family law organized succession of ancestral sacrifice and property inheritance through the father-son line (Shiga, 1967). These posts attack this system for being unable to verify its biological premise.

Research on Chinese digital feminism has mainly examined feminist campaigns around sexual harassment, censorship of feminist organizing, and the state's treatment of organized feminism as a political threat, such as the 2015 Feminist Five detentions, the banning of the leading feminist account Feminist Voices, and waves of keyword censorship (Wallis, 2015; Hong Fincher, 2018; Zeng, 2019). It also documents subtler constraints, such as official media reframing gender violence in de-gendered terms (Yang et al., 2025), and commercial platform culture channeling feminism toward consumption and self-branding (Peng, 2021; Guo, 2022). Xiaohongshu is dominated by female users, so it becomes a central platform to study digital feminism in China (Liu and Li, 2024). But even here, feminist advocacy is entangled with and sometimes gives way to commerce (Gu et al., 2024).

The feminist-lineage posts differ in their target of criticism. Rather than current policies or gender inequality, they target patrilineal genealogy in history. Therefore its sensitivity is unsure. Feminism itself is sensitive, but this interpretation focuses on history, not current problems.

2.5 Materials and *Dream of the Red Chamber* and *Suoyin* Decoding

Posts also use different materials to build arguments, and the same material can support different interpretations, so I code political interpretation and material separately. In the tables and figures the material variable is "carrier."

Some posts assemble Qing genealogical charts, some quote historical records, some cite palace television dramas, and some decode *Dream of the Red Chamber*. This section explains the last kind.

As one of the most canonical Chinese novels, *Dream of the Red Chamber* was written in the mid-Qing and depicted an aristocratic family's rise and fall. *Suoyin*, literally "searching for the hidden," refers to a style of treating fictional characters, names, and plot details as clues to concealed historical persons and events when interpreting literary works. These coding and decoding practices reflect a long-standing pattern in which fiction served as a medium of commentary on state power (Ge, 2015).

Using this way to read *Dream of the Red Chamber* can be traced to 1917 when Cai Yuanpei, later president of Peking University, published a *suoyin* study arguing that the novel was a political text of the Kangxi court, mourning the Ming and indicting Manchu rule, and identified its protagonist Jia Baoyu with Kangxi's deposed heir Yinreng. In response, Hu Shi's landmark 1921 textual scholarship attacked this allegorical style as forced guessing and helped establish the evidentiary approach later known as "New Redology" (Yu, 1997: 3–52).

In the Hong–Kangxi event, the folklore version of the tension between these two reading ways can also be observed. The posts mainly adopted Cai's *suoyin* way, while criticizing Hu's evidentiary way. Users matched the novel's characters to the Hong–Kangxi event's characters, and read the novel as a coded record of true history erased by official Qing history books.

Earlier *suoyin* reading had already tied the novel to Ming loyalism and anti-Manchu politics, so contemporary users drew on a literary tradition with existing political associations, even though the posts didn't oppose Qing explicitly. However, it deserves noting that *Red Chamber* material appears across all three serious interpretations, and most of the posts using this material advance none of them.

2.6 Rhetorical Mode: What Posts Were Doing

The posts have four main kinds of participation which I call rhetorical modes: asserting or correcting the rumour publicly; watching and joking (the gossip participation often described online as "eating melon"); assembling evidence such as timelines, charts, and sources; and asking questions without settling on a conclusion. These activities are independent from interpretation and can combine with different interpretations in different ways. For example, a feminist-lineage claim can appear as a joke, while an evidence thread can advance any of the three interpretations.

In summary, I code four features of each post: the interpretation it advances, the cultural material it uses, the type of participation it performs, and the location of its main message. In the tables and figures these variables are labelled interpretation, carrier, mode, and legibility.

3 Public Search and Chinese Information Control

Previous studies on Chinese online censorship have made significant achievements. One of the most famous arguments is that the target of deleting is not content criticizing the government, but content with collective action potential. Related to offline collective events, whether supporting or criticizing the government, posts are deleted with high intensity; lacking collective action potential, even the sharpest attacks on the regime are not deleted (King et al., 2013). Lorentzen (2014) proposes partial censorship model to explain how the Party benefits from negative news that supervise local governments, while regulating public dissatisfaction in an acceptable sum. Sun and Zhao (2022) systematically review previous literature, and overcome their weakness by studying the WeChat public account they operate by themselves and interviewing relevant officials, and they find that the state only provides credible threat, while most of the work is delegated to platform censorship teams, and users' own self-censorship. Platforms themselves are commercial actors that comply with censorship demands while competing for user attention (Han, 2018: 55–76).

Roberts (2018) combs through China's censorship history and explains what she calls "control minimizing the perception of control" (Roberts, 2018: 101–103). Since most of the public is rationally ignorant, friction—the increasing of time, effort, or other costs to information access, and flooding—the infusion of positive information, can prevent the public from sensitive information. They are the main practices in the Xi era.

Gillespie (2022) uses "reduction" to describe the demotion or exclusion of hosted content from rankings, recommendations, and search. It overlaps with "friction," but is still a bit different. Friction is a practice of strategically increasing information costs, while reduction describes a wider set of platform practices that shape information circulation, which can arise through both censorship and recommendation systems or search design.

Existing studies also demonstrate that Chinese search engines systematically filter and reorder search results to align with state regulations. These practices decide which information remains accessible to public, thereby shaping the boundaries of public discourse and user perception (Jiang, 2014).

As previous literature suggests, the main field where censorship functions may not be hard deletion, but decreasing accessibility; and public search is an important route for users to find posts, especially when they do not follow the author or possess a working link. The latter is especially important on Xiaohongshu, since its post link expires in a short time. As a result, I believe it is also meaningful to explore censorship through public search, given it is a moderate measurement of the public's information access, though it cannot tell which actors or process leads to the observed access.

Nationalist expression also provides a good setting for studying limited information access, be-

cause it is not uniformly encouraged or suppressed in China. Weiss (2014) shows that authorities may permit popular nationalist mobilization when it serves policy goals and restrain it when it threatens other priorities. The Hong–Kangxi event broadly appears nationalist, but has conflicting political interpretations, so its different interpretations may be treated differently. Besides, collecting posts during an event and searching them later may provide a way to study a problem proposed in digital nationalism research: from a corpus assembled at one later moment, researchers cannot tell whether heterodox positions were rare from the outset or were "rendered invisible by the combination of censorship and platform affordances" (Zhang et al., 2024: 1903). Since I collected the posts when the discussion was heated, the results can contribute to this question.

I test whether a post can still be found by entering the first twenty characters of its title, or the opening body text when it does not have an available title, and recording whether the original post ID appears among the rendered search results. A post is coded as findable when this procedure returns its original post ID; otherwise it is coded as non-findable. The variable used in the analysis is public-search non-findability, the failure of this test.

4 Data and Measurement

4.1 Platform and Corpus

Xiaohongshu, founded in Shanghai in 2013 and known internationally as RedNote, describes itself as a lifestyle community where users share shopping, beauty, travel, food, and daily-life experience through image-and-text notes and video (Xiaohongshu, n.d.). Its monthly active users passed 100 million in 2020 and reached roughly 300 million by the end of 2023, half of them born after 1995, strongly female-skewed (Xiaohongshu, 2024; Rest of World, 2025). Three features of it matter for this study: post discovery relies heavily on both recommendation and deliberate search, users are mostly female, and content is primarily around lifestyle and entertainment rather than explicit political discussion.

I collected posts in November 2025 during the event wave, using the open-source crawler MediaCrawler on GitHub (NanmiCoder, n.d.). I used three search keywords. The first is 康熙瓜 ("Kangxi melon"), and the internet slang "melon" means gossip. To my knowledge, few historical discussions before put "Kangxi" and "melon" together, so I believe it would reliably retrieve Hong–Kangxi event posts. The second, 洪承畴 (Hong Chengchou), is the name of Kangxi's alleged father in the rumor. The third, 伪史 ("pseudo-history"), was used to collect Western pseudo-history posts. After reviewing I found this interpretation's vocabulary does not always overlap with the rumour's, since many of the pseudo-history posts do not use the label "pseudo-history"; and it was also hard to tell their shared key words, so this keyword is the only one I could use, though it is not so eligible. The third keyword captures only part of the broader

discourse. A candidate keyword, 悼明 ("mourning the Ming"), was tested and dropped because it mostly returned material unrelated to the event.

The raw crawl contains 2,797 keyword hits. 107 of them were unrelated noise posts and removed. 2,690 left were manually reviewed and divided into three sets: 1,594 posts belonging to the Hong–Kangxi event, 593 standalone Western pseudo-history posts unconnected to the event, and 503 general historical-analysis posts.

These 1,594 event posts are this study's corpus. Each record includes title, caption and body text, post type (text-only, image-text, and video), engagement counts at collection, publishing date, and all the images. I then used OCR to extract the text words on their images.

Publishing dates show that the number of event posts rises from 3 November 2025, peaks on 5 November, and stays active through mid-month. Since the crawl was conducted several days after this topic got popular, some posts may have already been removed, and the most rapidly removed posts are plausibly the most sensitive, so the observed date distribution may not be the full original wave; but my collection was before the official commentary was published, so its bias may be small.

4.2 Measuring the Outcome

In April 2026, I re-searched every post through Xiaohongshu's public search interface as described before. Of the 1,594 event posts, 767 were findable, 804 were not, and 23 returned technical errors and are excluded from analysis.

I randomly sampled 100 of the 804 unfindable posts, and attempted to locate each through its author's profile page. 32 of them were removed from their authors' profiles, while 27 remained on the author's profile yet could not be returned through search. The latter can be seen as an example of the information friction Roberts describes—the content exists, and the cost of reaching it has risen. 41 could not be verified. Table 1 reports the result.

User names on Xiaohongshu are not unique or fixed, and users can adopt the same name as others or change their name at any time. The collected data does not contain stable account ID, so when a post's author could not be confidently matched to a profile, I cannot tell whether the post was removed or not. These 41 cases are therefore unclassifiable.

Table 1: Audit of a random sample of 100 search-absent posts

Audit outcome	Count	Interpretation
Gone from identifiable author profile	32	Hard disappearance; platform deletion and author deletion cannot be distinguished.
Visible on profile but absent from search	27	The post remains visible on the profile but cannot be found through public search.
Author or post unverifiable	41	Display names not unique; profile could not be confidently matched.

4.3 What the Coding Records

Each post was coded on the dimensions introduced in Section 2. Human coders and models coded the posts independently based on their texts, OCR texts and hashtags, and were not allowed to infer from outside knowledge.

The codebook captures five main dimensions of each post. First, political interpretation is a non-exclusive variable recording whether a post explicitly advances anti-Manchu/Qing, anti-Western pseudo-history, or feminist-lineage interpretation. Merely mentioning the rumour or displaying related materials without endorsing the interpretation does not qualify; posts advancing none of these are coded all 0 in three indicators.

Second, rhetorical mode. It identifies a post's dominant communicative action, including four mutually exclusive categories: "public claim or correction" (making, endorsing, or rejecting a claim), "information or evidence work" (simply organizing or sharing evidence materials such as historical records, without making a claim), "inquiry or reflection" (expressing genuine uncertainty or personal reflection without making a claim), or "playful spectatorship" (treating the event primarily as gossip or entertainment).

Third, an indicator that the post focuses on organizing evidence, named "evidence-work". Assembling and evaluating evidence could appear in different modes—posts of "public claim or correction" can also do the work, and such posts tend to be long and full of historical materials, which could affect findability, so I introduce a binary evidence-work indicator, to capture posts that assemble a large volume of evidentiary materials (e.g., timelines, genealogies, or screenshots), regardless of their dominant rhetorical mode.

Fourth, cultural carrier is coded to record the specific historical or cultural materials the posts use, including Hong–Kangxi rumour-specific materials, *Dream of the Red Chamber suoyin* materials, popular cultural works such as modern palace dramas and novels, and broader historical or political materials.

Fifth, legibility is coded to assess how easily a post's core message can be searched with characters, based on the location of the post's main message. It has four kinds: having search-

able caption/title text (high caption legibility), text mainly embedded in images and needing OCR extraction (medium OCR legibility), using videos with substantial caption texts (medium caption-video), and images or videos without substantial text (low visual/video legibility).

Engagement is also included as the log of total numbers of likes, collections, and comments when collected. Highly engaged posts may be both easier to find since they tend to be recommended by platform, or easier to be deleted if they contain sensitive things. But posts' engagement is influenced by many factors, including their content, so it is not a simple pre-treatment control. As a result, the main estimates are reported both with and without it.

4.4 Coding Workflow, Validation, and Reliability

The final codebook was developed through three pilot rounds covering 160 distinct posts (190 codings in total, 30 of them are borderline cases from earlier rounds).

In each round, human coders and LLMs coded independently, and disagreements were examined to identify unclear category boundaries and revise the codebook.

For example, early versions would put all interpretations and materials involved in the Hong–Kangxi event in one "topic" label, leading to *Red Chamber* literary reading related to the event and anti-Qing argument as the same topic, which made a category very heterogeneous inside. The final codebook then separates interpretation, mode, and material.

Through three rounds, adjustments combined with close reading made me confident that the categories can capture the political and rhetorical distinctions I intend to study, so the category definitions and decision rules were fixed.

Then I evaluated reliability on 228 posts that had not been used in the codebook development. The posts were collected from two draws. The first took 170 posts at random from the event corpus, while the second took 70 posts at random from the posts whose text contains at least one of ten keywords associated with the three interpretations, such as "genealogy" (族谱), "ancestral hall" (祠堂), and "Great Ming" (大明), to over-sample posts near the category boundaries where coding is hard. The two draws actually returned 228 useful posts. Two human coders independently coded them with the final codebook, then computed the disagreement statistics.

Since coders will agree on some posts simply because a category is uncommon, Cohen's κ is reported. Cohen's κ adjusts the observed agreement by the amount of agreement expected from the two coders' overall use of the categories. A value of 1 means complete agreement, and 0 means any overlap in their coding is entirely due to chance. On the 228 posts with usable interpretation coding, the primary coder identified 31 anti-Manchu/Qing posts and the second coder identified 34, among them 24 were overlapping. The raw agreement was therefore 211/228, 92.5%. Since most posts were negative, however, much of that agreement was easy to obtain. After correcting for the agreement expected from the coders' positive and negative rates, Co-

hen's κ was 0.695.[1] Among posts labelled anti-Manchu/Qing by at least one human coder, the coders disagreed on 17 of 41 cases. The difficulty is that loud historical gossip and anti-Qing claims are hard to classify.

Since the political interpretations are rare, positive-class F1 is also reported. Kappa evaluates agreement across both positive and negative decisions, while F1 focuses on whether the coders identify the same positive cases. So it falls when a coder either adds many false positives or misses many positive cases. For anti-Manchu/Qing, F1 score was 0.739. Even through the previous three rounds, two humans do not fully converge on which posts carry this interpretation.

Among all the coding terms, political interpretation got the highest human–human agreement. Macro κ, the unweighted average across the three interpretation labels, was 0.762, while macro positive F1 = 0.783, showing that the fixed rules can be applied consistently by independent coders.

Anti-Manchu/Qing was the most difficult ($\kappa = 0.695$, F1 = 0.739). Feminist-lineage was the most reproducible ($\kappa = 0.936$, F1 = 0.943), and two readers rarely disagree about this interpretation. *Red Chamber* material was also reliable enough to be included in regression ($\kappa = 0.803$ and F1 = 0.841). Rhetorical mode got $\kappa = 0.677$, which is a bit low because some posts are difficult to classify neatly.

Then the candidate LLMs independently coded the same 228 posts, and their outcomes were compared with the primary human coder's outcome. The best model achieved a macro $\kappa = 0.714$ for the three interpretations, close to the 0.762 between the two human coders. In practical terms, that means on these interpretations, the best model disagreed with the primary coder roughly as often as the second human coder. Anti-Manchu/Qing remained the most difficult boundary.

The best two LLMs, GPT-5.4 and DeepSeek V4-Pro Thinking, then coded all 1,594 event posts. Literature on LLM-assisted annotation recommends validating model output against human-coded data after the coding rules are fixed, using more than one model, and concentrating human review where errors matter most. Agreement between models is not sufficient on its own, because models can share the same errors (Törnberg, 2024; Ziems et al., 2024). I manually reviewed every post that the two models disagreed on rhetorical mode, and every post that either model labeled as one of the three interpretations, which are in total 623 posts.

I expected political direction and rhetorical mode to matter for later findability and did not expect the material variable to, so I gave the former two factors most attention while material labels got the least review, relying on the model. But the results went the other way: the material variable carries the largest association.

[1] $\kappa = (P_o - P_e)/(1 - P_e)$, where P_o is observed agreement and P_e is the agreement expected from the coders' marginal label frequencies.

For the remaining 971 posts, if LLMs had disagreements on material coding, GPT-5.4 labels were adopted. But DeepSeek outputs were used for sensitivity analysis, by respectively putting the union (posts labeled positive by either GPT-5.4 or DeepSeek) and the intersection (posts labeled positive by both models) into regression.

Every post labeled as any interpretation by either model was reviewed by me, so false positives would be few; but posts assigned no political interpretation were not reviewed, which can lead to false negatives. So I use the reliability sample to estimate the share of human-coded positive posts the two models would have missed, following Egami et al. (2024).

In the reliability sample, at least one model marked 23 of the 31 posts that the human coder marked as anti-Manchu/Qing, 24 of the 25 feminist-lineage posts, and 6 of the 7 anti-Western posts. Among the positives that both models missed, 2 anti-Manchu/Qing posts would still be read by a human because the models disagreed about their rhetorical modes, leaving 6 anti-Manchu/Qing positives, 1 feminist-lineage positive, and 1 anti-Western positive that would not be reviewed. Since the reliability sample was constructed by over-sampling posts that are hard to code, these raw counts may overstate how common such misses are in the corpus. I therefore weight each sampled post by the inverse of its known selection probability. Figure 1 plots these weighted rates: an estimated 98 percent of feminist-lineage positives and 92 percent of anti-Western positives would have been recognized by at least one model. However, only 76 percent of anti-Manchu/Qing positives (95% CI [0.52, 0.91]) were successfully recognized. Applying these weighted miss rates to the 971 posts not reviewed by me, the models likely missed roughly 23 posts advancing the anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation, 1 anti-West and 1 feminist-lineage post.

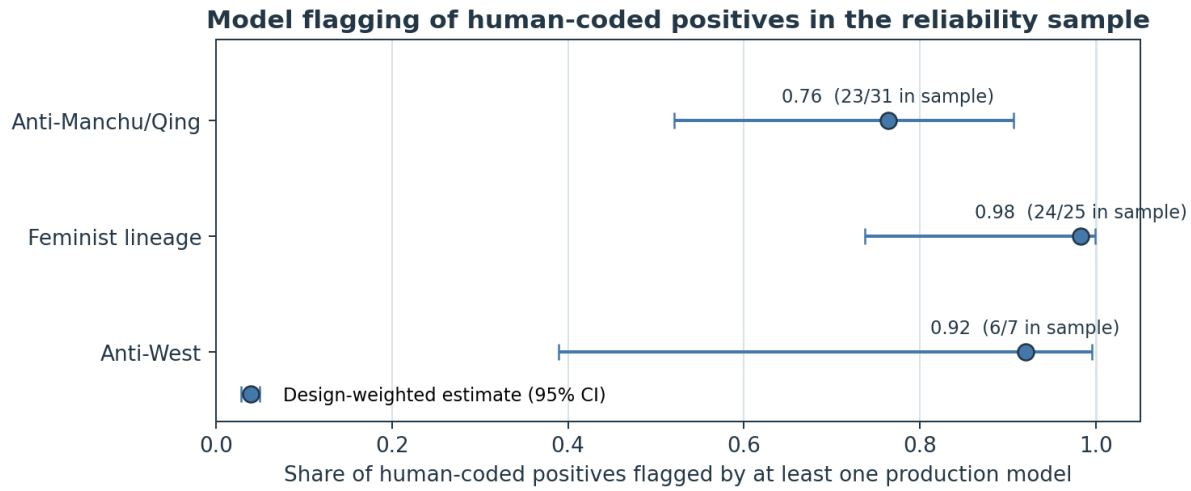


Figure 1: Model flagging of human-coded positives in the reliability sample. Points are the weighted share of human-coded positives that at least one production model flagged for human review; lines are 95% confidence intervals. Counts are unweighted sample counts.

For the material coding, GPT-5.4 successfully recognized 45 of the 46 *Red Chamber* posts

coded positive by humans, but also generated 10 false positives. Applying the inverse probability weighting described above, its recall was 96% and its precision was 78%. Therefore false positive is the main problem for *Red Chamber* indicator, which may work against finding an association, because posts that don't use *Red Chamber* materials may be mixed into the *Red Chamber* group, leading to the estimate understating the association. Union and intersection described above are also used to do sensitivity checks for this category.

Cross-model agreement on the full corpus was $\kappa = 0.655$ for rhetorical mode; and 0.607 for anti-Manchu/Qing, 0.916 for anti-West, 0.892 for feminist lineage.

The overall approach, scaled model coding combined with targeted human reading, follows methods for large text corpora (Lichtenstein and Rucks-Ahidiana, 2023).

5 Descriptive Results

Within the corpus, the most prevalent rhetorical mode is public claims or corrections ($n = 609$), followed by playful spectatorship ($n = 441$). Information or evidence work posts and inquiry posts appear at similar frequencies (238 and 225 respectively), while 81 posts cannot be classified (see Figure 2). As Figure 3 shows, only a small fraction of the corpus explicitly advances one of the three target interpretations: feminist-lineage ($n = 98$), anti-Manchu/Qing ($n = 91$), and anti-Western ($n = 14$). Roughly seven-eighths of all posts do not advance any of the interpretations.

For the use of cultural materials, Hong–Kangxi event-specific materials are used most commonly ($n = 878$), followed by broader historical-political materials ($n = 293$), *Red Chamber suoyin* material ($n = 235$), and popular culture material ($n = 218$). It's worth noting that the vast majority of posts that use *Red Chamber* materials do not advance any of the three interpretations. With regard to legibility, 728 posts contain highly searchable caption text, and a large number of posts rely on a mix of images and text ($n = 570$), or video / image with little text ($n = 288$ across images and videos). Because over a third of the corpus depends heavily on image-embedded text which indexes poorly in public search engines, I hold message location constant in the regression model.

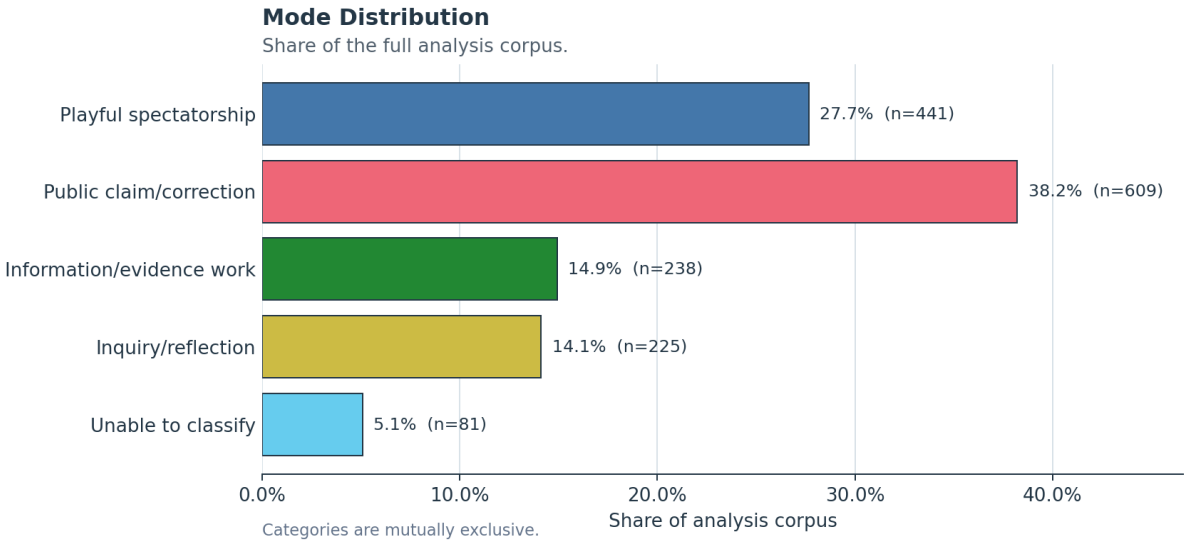


Figure 2: Participation modes in the event corpus (N = 1,594). Primary modes are reported mutually exclusive. Percentages use the full corpus as the denominator.

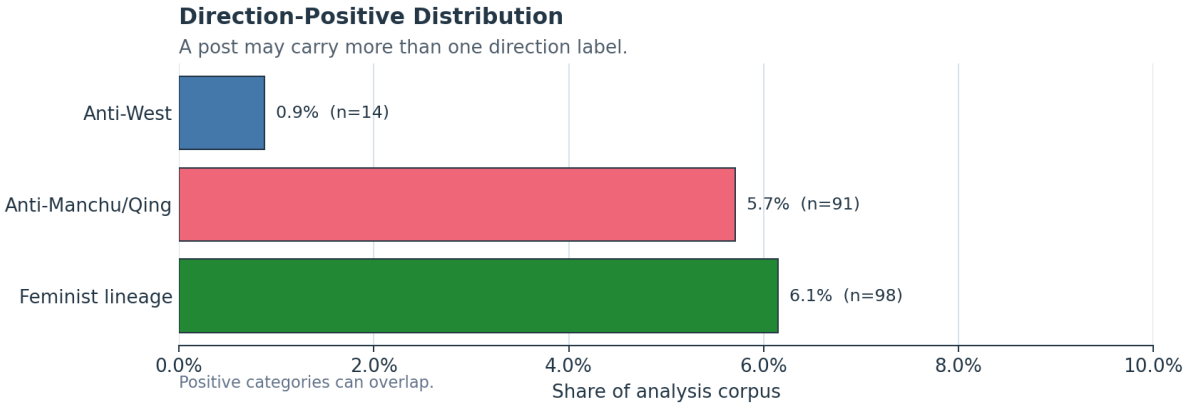


Figure 3: Positive interpretation labels in the event corpus (N = 1,594). Interpretation labels are non-exclusive, so a post may appear in more than one bar. Percentages use the full corpus as the denominator.

6 Associations with Public-Search Findability

The main analysis utilizes a logistic regression to predict non-findability based on the coded features (summarized in Table 2 and plotted in Figure 4). After excluding 23 posts with technical verification errors and 108 with missing data, the final estimation sample contains 1,463 posts. The model incorporates robust standard errors and controls for rhetorical mode, cultural materials, evidence-work, message location, post type, publishing date, crawling keyword fixed effects, and logged character counts. The main results are reported both with and without logged engagement.

6.1 Main Results

Table 2 reports odds ratios with 95 percent confidence intervals for the key terms, and Figure 4 plots them.

Table 2: Key logit results for search non-findability (N = 1,463)

Term	With engagement OR [95% CI]	AME	Without engagement OR [95% CI]
Anti-West interpretation	0.53 [0.15, 1.81]	−0.146	0.53 [0.16, 1.73]
Anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation	1.27 [0.77, 2.09]	+0.057	1.29 [0.80, 2.11]
Feminist-lineage interpretation	2.06 [1.22, 3.46]	+0.165	1.90 [1.14, 3.16]
Hong–Kangxi carrier	0.86 [0.68, 1.09]	−0.036	0.85 [0.67, 1.08]
Red Chamber suoyin carrier	2.30 [1.64, 3.21]	+0.192	2.24 [1.61, 3.12]
Medium OCR legibility	1.37 [1.05, 1.79]	+0.073	1.33 [1.02, 1.74]
Log engagement	0.93 [0.89, 0.97]		not included

Note: Logistic regression; controls include participation type, evidence work, the remaining material and searchable-text categories, post type, posting date, keyword fixed effects, and log text length. Robust standard errors. AME is the average marginal effect on the probability of non-findability in the with-engagement model.

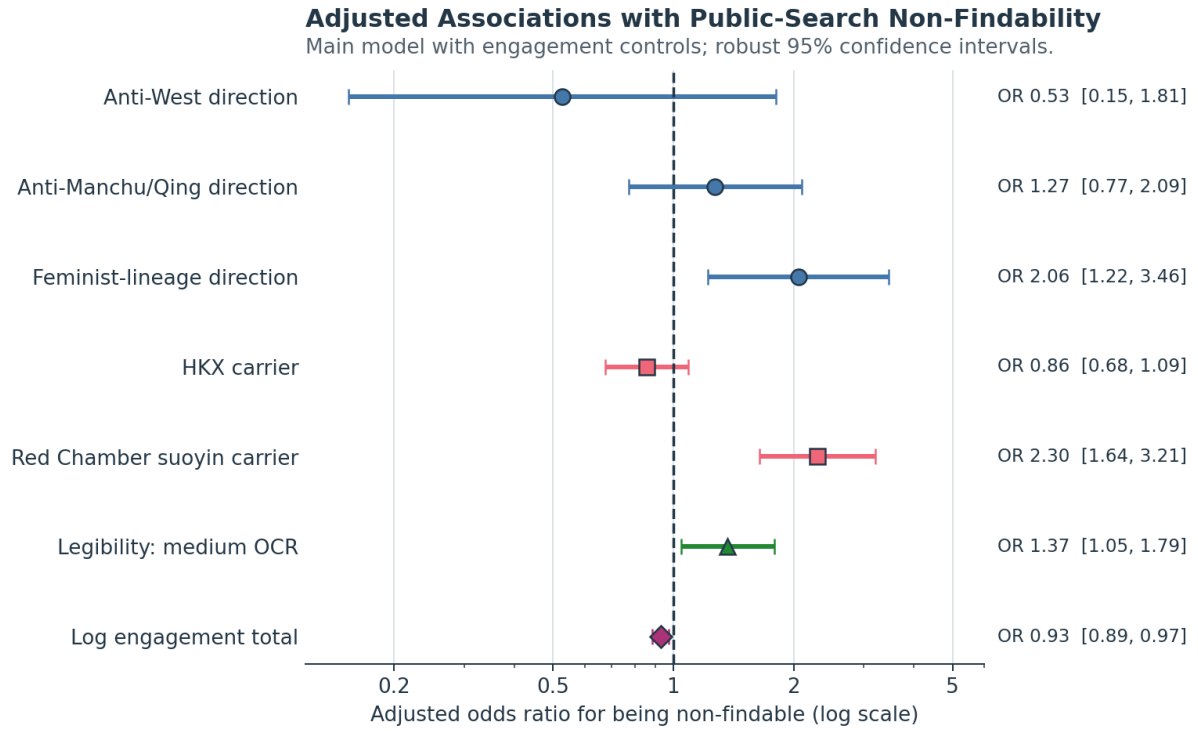


Figure 4: Adjusted associations with search non-findability in the main model. Points are odds ratios and horizontal lines are robust 95% confidence intervals; the dashed vertical line marks an odds ratio of 1. Values greater than 1 indicate higher adjusted odds of non-findability, while values below 1 indicate higher adjusted odds of findability. HKX abbreviates Hong–Kangxi.

Among the political interpretations, the feminist-lineage is the only one demonstrating a stable

positive association with non-findability. Controlling for engagement, this narrative yields an odds ratio (OR) of 2.06 and an average marginal effect of 0.165, namely an approximate 16-percentage-point increase in the probability of being unfindable (the OR remains robust at 1.90 without engagement). The anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation, arguably the event's most direct challenge to official historiography, shows a positive but statistically unstable association (OR = 1.27, 95% CI encompasses 1). Meanwhile, only 14 posts advance anti-Western interpretation, therefore lacking sufficient statistical power.

Notably, the *Red Chamber suoyin* material exhibits the largest adjusted association among all focal predictors (OR = 2.30). Even when holding the political interpretations, rhetorical mode, engagement, and all other controls constant, the presence of this cultural material increases the probability of non-findability by an average marginal effect of 0.19.

Posts whose message is mainly carried by image and video are also less findable than posts with searchable texts (OR = 1.37). This association is consistent with hypotheses about search indexes. Better-engaged posts are modestly more findable.

6.2 Separating Material from Interpretation

To clarify whether *Red Chamber* association is produced by the material itself, or by the material in combination with political interpretation, I classify posts with and without interpretation within the *Red Chamber* posts. In the estimation sample, 222 posts contain *Red Chamber* material (13 were excluded because of coding error), 183 of them use it without political interpretations, 31 use it with anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation, and 8 use it with other interpretations.

Their non-findability rates are 47 percent, 64 percent, and 84 percent respectively. In adjusted models, *Red Chamber* material remains associated with non-findability even among posts that advance none of the three interpretations (OR = 2.14, 95% CI [1.51, 3.04]). When *Red Chamber* material appears together with the anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation, the estimate is larger but much less precise (OR = 6.35, 95% CI [1.95, 20.68]). The group with the other two interpretations only contains 8 posts, so it is uninformative (OR = 1.06, 95% CI [0.21, 5.31]; Figure 5).

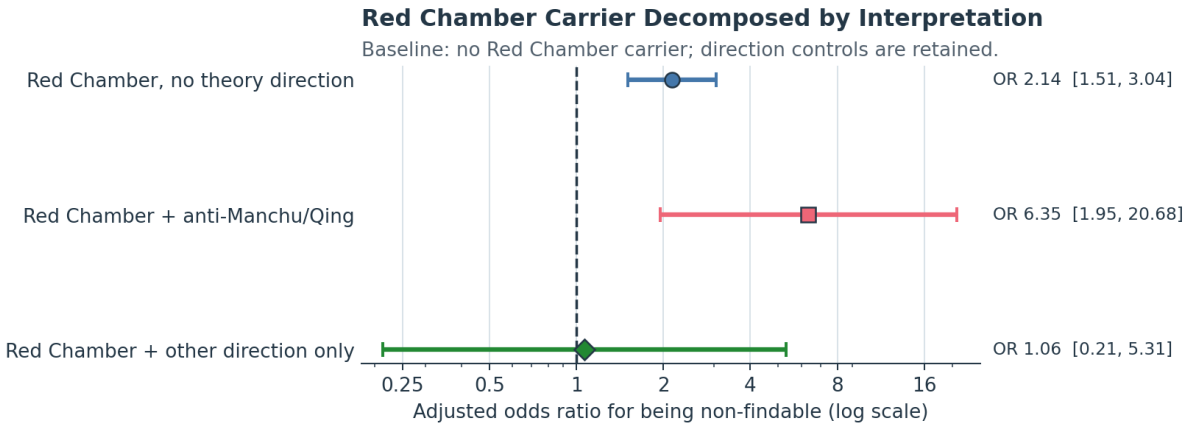


Figure 5: *Red Chamber* material decomposed by interpretation. Points are adjusted odds ratios relative to posts without *Red Chamber* material; horizontal lines are robust 95% confidence intervals and the dashed line marks an odds ratio of 1. The groups are mutually exclusive.

6.3 Robustness

Replacing the interpretation labels with union and intersection, and replacing the material labels with union and intersection, the feminist-lineage and *Red Chamber* estimates remain positive, and the anti-Manchu/Qing estimate also remains positive but unstable. Excluding engagement, or excluding low-engagement posts, these results remain.

Since *Red Chamber* content often appears in long image-text notes, I estimate the *Red Chamber* association within different message locations. The association remains positive among posts whose message is mainly carried by texts (OR = 2.40, 95% CI [1.55, 3.70]) and posts that rely on image or video but also have text (OR = 2.10, 95% CI [1.17, 3.77]), while the outcome of posts whose message is mainly in image or video is imprecise, which contain only 15 *Red Chamber* posts (Figure 6).

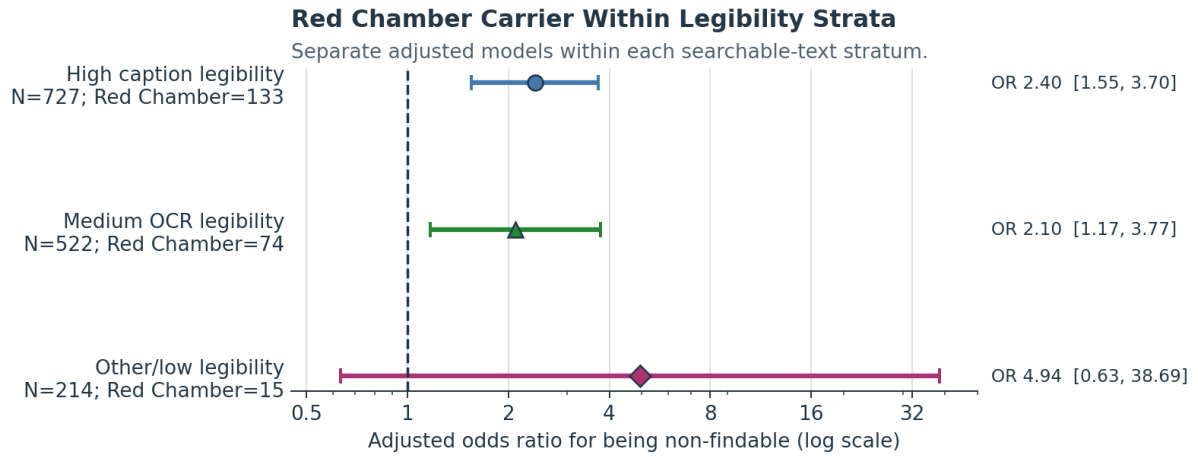


Figure 6: *Red Chamber* material associations within searchable-text strata. Each point comes from a separate adjusted logit model; horizontal lines are robust 95% confidence intervals and the dashed line marks an odds ratio of 1.

7 Discussion

7.1 Interpreting the Pattern

The findings do not show a simple order in which the interpretation that challenges official history narratives most directly becomes the least findable. Anti-Manchu/Qing posts directly challenged the inclusion of Qing within Chinese historical continuity and later received explicit criticism from a provincial Party media account, yet their estimated association with non-findability was unstable. The associations instead appeared among feminist-lineage posts, *Red Chamber* posts, and posts whose main message is not carried by text.

The unstable anti-Manchu/Qing estimate may partly reflect a measurement difficulty. This interpretation was more dependent on context and was harder to distinguish from ordinary historical discussion. As explained above, roughly 23 posts likely entered the analysis coded as no interpretation, which may also lower the estimate. In contrast, feminist-lineage posts often used recurring language about maternity, paternity, genealogy, surnames, and the paternal line, and were highly reproducible across human coders ($\kappa = 0.936$).

What is interesting is that the *Red Chamber* association remained among posts that made no explicit political claim, and posts with different message locations. Therefore it cannot be treated simply as a proxy for anti-Manchu/Qing interpretation or image-heavy format, but may have its own effect.

Together, the results show that direct political meaning alone cannot explain the pattern.

7.2 Implications

This study indicated that the unit of analysis should be noted in censorship studies. A topic-level indicator might put all posts in the Hong–Kangxi event into one category and miss the difference in posts' meanings. But as shown above, the same rumor can support anti-Qing arguments and feminist critiques, can be combined with pseudo-history discourse, and can be seen as ordinary gossip. These different usages of the rumor became unequally findable on one platform.

Different levels of findability may also shape what remains easy to recall as the public record of an event. Jiang (2014) calls the strongest version of this process "virtual political disappearance." This study shows one necessary step toward such an outcome: some previously observed posts later became harder to find than others. If similar patterns recur across different events, they may influence collective memory and forgetting. That larger claim requires repeated observation across events and platforms to test.

The feminist-lineage posts add a less familiar form of Chinese feminist expression to previous studies. They were aimed at historical patrilineal rules rather than modern policy, and appeared inside an entertainment event, sometimes in a playful tone, but still among the least findable content in the corpus.

7.3 Limitations and Future Research

This study examines one platform for one event at one date, and cannot identify which actor or process produces the observed pattern.

The coding also has some classification errors that may influence regression. Some posts may advance an interpretation but not be recognized, while some posts labeled as using a material may not use it.

Egami et al. (2024) propose design-based supervised learning (DSL) for this setting: automated labels are combined with probability-sampled expert annotations inside the downstream estimator, allowing prediction error to be incorporated into point estimates and uncertainty. Future work can apply this method, showing whether the substantive findings change after classification error is incorporated directly into the regression.

Another limitation is that the 160 posts used to develop the codebook were also included in the final regression. These should have been excluded to prevent the coding rules from overfitting to the idiosyncrasies of that specific sample (Egami et al., 2022). But the codebook was revised in response to coding disagreements about content categories, not to the posts' later findability outcomes, which may reduce concern about outcome-driven overfitting.

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